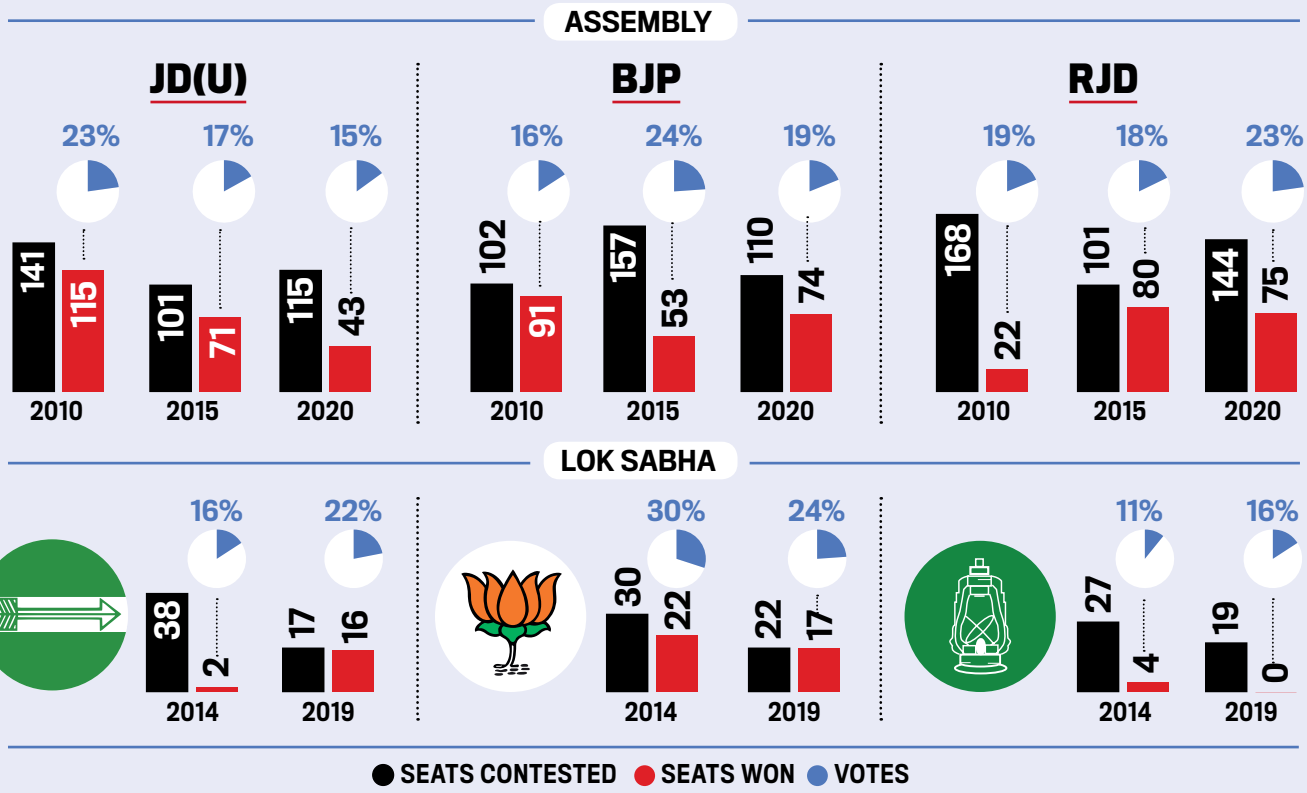
BIHAR ELECTIONS: TOP 3 PERFORMERS

DIMINISHING ELECTORAL RETURNS COULD BE A FACTOR IN NITISH'S FLIP-FLOPS



MATURE IN HIS RESPONSE TO NITISH'S EXIT, TEJASHWI SAID "*KHEL ABHI BAAKI HAI*" AND PREDICTED THE END OF JD(U) POST THE 2024 POLLS

game is not over)" remark has already served notice that the new government will face some sound and fury when the budget session starts on February 10. Predicting that the JD(U) would disintegrate after the 2024 general election because of the BJP's machinations, he said, "*Main jo kehta hoon, woh karta hoon* (I do what I say). This is now between the performance of my 17 months in government versus his 17 years as CM," while going on to take credit for the jobs created during his term as deputy CM (a fact Nitish pooh-poohed).

However, immediately after the break-up, the RJD was in the midst of a legal challenge with the Enforcement Directorate descending on Patna to question Lalu and Tejashwi in the alleged land for railway job scam from back when Yadav Sr was rail minister (2004-09). The timing of the questioning, just a day after Nitish walked out, led RJD leaders to scream "political vendetta".

Tejashwi's biggest challenge now is to expand the RJD's voter base beyond the core Muslim-Yadav support. RJD leaders believe Tejashwi has scored high by weaving his father's social justice theme with his employment and empowerment politics. This is the narrative the party will push this election season, along with the one about being back-stabbed by Nitish.

THE SAFFRON EMBRACE

The Bharat Ratna to Karpoori Thakur gave Nitish the excuse to publicly embrace the BJP again. The latter, too, saw it as a win-win—win big in Bihar in the LS poll and also build the narrative of the collapse of the I.N.D.I.A. bloc. The central BJP leadership apparently felt that the combined BJP-JD(U) vote bank could give them an unassailable lead in Bihar. This is also why it prevailed upon the state leaders to fall in line. Bihar, with 40 Lok Sabha seats, is crucial for the BJP as it seeks a third consecutive term at the Centre in 2024. Last time around, its combine had won 39 seats.

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY